University of St.Gallen

# Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

# 7,514 | 8,514: Rethinking Organizations in a Complex World

# ECTS credits: 6

## Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (50%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time

## Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,514,1.00 Rethinking Organizations in a Complex World -- English -- Blagoev Blagoy Valentinov

## Course information

### Prerequisites

None.

### Learning objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- Understand the concept of polycrisis and explain its implications for organizational theory and practice.
- Analyze organizations using four distinct theoretical lenses—structural, informational, cultural, and political—each offering unique insights into how organizations function and fail in times of complexity.
- Critically evaluate organizational responses to complex, interrelated challenges such as sustainability, digital transformation, human rights, and social inequality.
- Synthesize insights across theoretical lenses to diagnose complex organizational problems and formulate coherent, theory-informed solutions.
- Design reflexive and adaptive strategies that consider systemic interdependencies, long-term consequences, and power dynamics in organizational settings.
- Collaborate effectively across disciplinary perspectives, contributing both theoretical depth and integrative thinking in group-based analysis and presentation.
- Reflect on their own assumptions and roles in shaping organizational futures amidst global uncertainty, acting as thoughtful, responsible actors in business and society.

### Content

In today's polycrisis – where overlapping global crises like climate change, pandemics, inequality, digital disinformation, and geopolitical instability interact in unpredictable and amplifying ways – organizations face unprecedented levels of complexity. Hence, they must learn to navigate tangled crises that reinforce each other through cascading feedback loops and emergent systemic shocks. This course invites students to rethink how organizations should function in such complex contexts by integrating four analytical lenses – structural, informational, cultural, and political – that together reveal how organizations can sense, interpret, and respond to conditions of complexity. The structural lens examines how formal design, role configurations, and adaptive routines can enable resilience or deepen fragility; the informational lens reveals how organizations deploy attention, sense-making capabilities, and communication to develop a shared understandings of complex situations; the cultural lens highlights how shared meaning, identity, and values shape collective interpretation and adaptive behavior; and

the political lens uncovers the internal and external power dynamics, legitimacy struggles, and stakeholder negotiations crucial in turbulent times. Through these lenses, students analyze challenges such as, e.g., digital transformation, sustainability, social inequality, and social polarization, developing nuanced understandings of how organizations can navigate the polycrisis. This multi-lens approach teaches students to design integrated, systemic strategies, framing problems as nested within interconnected social, ecological, and political systems, anticipating unintended consequences, identifying high-leverage entry points, and fostering organizational capacities for resilience and reflexivity in the face of complexity.

## Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

**Overview**

This course combines theoretical analysis with applied problem-solving by following a flipped classroom approach with a two-layered group structure. Students will join a theory group focused on one of the four lenses on organizations. Simultaneously, students will also join a second group focused on a practical organizational challenge, such as, e.g., sustainability transitions, digital transformation, social inequality, or societal polarization. Each practical group will include at least one student from each theory group.

**Teaching Format**

The course is delivered in four contact days, organized as follows:

**Kick-off Session (3 hours)**

- Introduction to the concept of polycrisis and the course objectives
- Overview of the four theoretical lenses: structural, informational, cultural, and political
- Formation of Theory Groups

**Block Day 1: Theoretical Deep-Dives (Full-day)**

- Theory Groups present their assigned lens to the class
- Instructor-led case illustrations and interactive discussions
- Formation of Practical Challenge Groups (cross-functional teams tackling a practical challenge)

**Block Day 2: Organizational Analysis Labs (Full-day)**

- Practical Groups analyze their assigned challenge through the four lenses
- Structured guidance and peer consultation across groups
- Mid-stage presentations and feedback

**Block Day 3: Solution Presentation & Synthesis (Full-day)**

- Final presentations and structured feedback from peers and instructor
- Closing reflection and synthesizing discussion

**Group-Based Learning Design**

- Theory Groups: Deep-dive into one organizational lens; responsible for teaching it to peers
- Practical Challenge Groups: Mixed groups applying all four lenses to a real-world issue.

**Flipped Classroom Approach**

Students are expected to:

- Prepare core readings before each session
- Engage actively in peer teaching
- Reflect critically on their learning in an individual essay

## Literature

These are introductory readings. A full list of literature will be provided at the beginning of the course.

Howard-Grenville, J., & Lahneman, B. 2021. Bringing the biophysical to the fore: Re-envisioning organizational adaptation in the era of planetary shifts. *Strategic Organization*, 19(3): 478–493.

Hernes, T., Blagoev, B., Kunisch, S., & Schultz, M. 2025. From Bouncing Back to Bouncing Forward: A Temporal Trajectory Model of Organizational Resilience. *Academy of Management Review*, 50(1): 72–92.

Blagoev, B., & Schreyögg, G. 2025. Eigenzeit: A New Lens on Temporal Complexity. *Academy of Management Review*, 50(1): 93–113.

## Additional information

--

# Examination information

## Examination sub part/s

## 1. Examination sub part (1/3)

### Examination modalities

| | |
|---|---|
| Examination type | Written work |
| Responsible for organisation | decentral |
| Examination form | Written work |
| Examination mode | Digital |
| Time of examination | Term time |
| Examination execution | Asynchronous |
| Examination location | Off Campus |
| Grading type | Individual work individual grade |
| Weighting | 50% |
| Duration | -- |

### Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

### Remark

Final essay

### Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

### Supplementary aids

--

## 2. Examination sub part (2/3)

### Examination modalities

| | |
|---|---|
| Examination type | Presentation |
| Responsible for organisation | decentral |
| Examination form | Oral examination |
| Examination mode | Analog |

| | |
|---|---|
| Time of examination | Term time |
| Examination execution | Asynchronous |
| Examination location | On Campus |
| Grading type | Group work group grade |
| Weighting | 25% |
| Duration | -- |

### Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

### Remark
Theory presentation

### Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

### Supplementary aids
--

## 3. Examination sub part (3/3)

### Examination modalities

| | |
|---|---|
| Examination type | Presentation |
| Responsible for organisation | decentral |
| Examination form | Oral examination |
| Examination mode | Analog |
| Time of examination | Term time |
| Examination execution | Asynchronous |
| Examination location | On Campus |
| Grading type | Group work group grade |
| Weighting | 25% |
| Duration | -- |

### Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

### Remark
Practical challenge presentation

### Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

### Supplementary aids
--

## Content

The assessment strategy is designed to evaluate students' understanding of organizational theory, their ability to apply it to complex real-world problems, and their capacity for critical reflection. It consists of three interrelated components that reflect the course's multi-perspective, collaborative, and practice-oriented approach.

**1. Theory Group Presentation (25%)**

- Students need to demonstrate deep understanding of one of the four theoretical lenses (structural, informational, cultural, political) and effectively communicate it to peers.
- Each Theory Group prepares a 30-minute teaching session.
- Presentations should include: core concepts and assumptions of the lens, illustrative examples, and connections to current organizational challenges.

**2. Practical Challenge Group Project (25%)**

- Objective: Apply all four theoretical lenses to analyze and address a complex organizational issue.
- Cross-functional groups work on one selected challenge on Block Day 2.
- Final output: a 20-minute presentation + supporting materials (e.g., slide deck, short memo).

**3. Final Essay (50%)**

- Objective: Critically reflect on the application of theoretical perspectives to organizational complexity in the context of the polycrisis.
- Students write a 3,000-word essay in response to a guiding prompt (provided at the end of the course).
- Expected to synthesize course readings, peer contributions, and personal learning.

## Literature

Equivalent to the course literature.

## Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).